

Business Travel Policy – California Employees

1. Purpose

The Company recognizes that business travel is an important component of conducting business, developing customer relationships, attending training programs, supporting operational activities, participating in conferences, conducting audits, meeting with suppliers, and representing the Company in professional settings. This policy establishes comprehensive requirements for business travel, reimbursement, safety, approvals, and expense management.

The objectives of this policy are to promote responsible stewardship of Company resources, ensure compliance with California law, provide consistent reimbursement practices, support employee safety and well-being, establish accountability, and ensure that travel expenditures are reasonable, necessary, and aligned with legitimate business needs.

2. Scope

This policy applies to all full-time employees, part-time employees, temporary employees, interns, and approved contractors who travel on behalf of the Company. The Company operates primarily from San Diego, California, with approved hybrid work arrangements available. The policy applies to domestic and international travel regardless of whether expenses are paid directly by the Company or reimbursed to the employee.

3. Guiding Principles

Employees are expected to exercise good judgment, spend Company funds responsibly, prioritize safety, comply with all laws and Company policies, and seek cost-effective travel options that meet business objectives. Travel should occur only when there is a legitimate business purpose that cannot reasonably be accomplished through virtual means.

4. Travel Authorization and Approval Process

All business travel requires advance manager approval. International travel, travel exceeding established budget thresholds, extended travel assignments, and exceptions to policy require executive approval. Travel requests should include business purpose, destination, expected costs, dates, and anticipated outcomes.

Managers are responsible for evaluating business necessity, budget availability, and compliance with Company requirements before approving travel.

5. Travel Planning Procedures

Employees should plan travel as early as practical. Airfare should generally be booked at least fourteen days in advance. Conference registration, hotel reservations, and transportation arrangements should be completed as soon as travel dates are confirmed.

Employees are encouraged to compare available options and select arrangements that balance safety, efficiency, productivity, and cost. Last-minute bookings that result in significantly higher costs may require additional justification.

6. Air Travel Policy

Economy-class airfare is the standard for Company-sponsored travel. Employees should select the lowest logical fare that meets business needs and avoid unnecessary upgrades.

Business-class airfare may be approved for international flights exceeding eight hours, documented medical accommodations, or exceptional business circumstances. First-class travel is generally not reimbursable.

Reasonable baggage fees, seat assignment fees, and business-related internet charges may be reimbursed when supported by receipts.

7. Hotel and Lodging Standards

Employees should select safe, reputable accommodations that support productivity and provide reasonable access to the business destination. The standard lodging reimbursement limit is \$200 per night before taxes and fees unless otherwise approved.

Factors to consider include safety, location, transportation costs, internet availability, and total trip cost. Conference hotels may exceed the standard limit when attendance at the event would otherwise be impractical or create additional costs.

8. Meal and Incidental Expense Policy

Employees may be reimbursed up to \$125 per person, per day for meals and incidental expenses while traveling on approved Company business. The daily allowance includes breakfast, lunch, dinner, snacks, beverages, and reasonable gratuities.

Employees are expected to exercise moderation and good judgment. Alcoholic beverages are generally not reimbursable unless specifically approved for client entertainment or Company-sponsored events.

9. Ground Transportation

Employees should utilize cost-effective transportation options including rideshare services, taxis, public transportation, airport shuttles, and rental vehicles when justified.

Transportation choices should reflect the most reasonable balance of cost, safety, and efficiency.

10. Rental Vehicles

Rental vehicles should generally be economy or standard-class vehicles. Luxury vehicles, sports cars, and premium upgrades are not reimbursable without advance approval. Employees are responsible for operating rental vehicles safely and complying with all traffic laws.

Employees should inspect rental vehicles before use and promptly report accidents or damage.

11. Personal Vehicle Use

Employees who use personal vehicles for approved business travel will be reimbursed at the current IRS standard mileage rate unless otherwise required by California law. Mileage reimbursement is intended to cover fuel, maintenance, insurance, depreciation, and normal operating costs.

Mileage logs should include dates, destinations, business purpose, and total miles traveled.

12. International Travel Requirements

International travel requires additional planning and preparation. Employees must ensure passport validity, obtain required visas, review destination-specific health and safety requirements, and comply with applicable customs, export control, and import regulations.

Employees should consult available government travel advisories and complete any required security training prior to departure.

13. Safety and Duty of Care

The Company is committed to supporting employee safety during business travel. Employees should remain aware of their surroundings, avoid unsafe situations, secure Company assets, and exercise caution when using transportation or lodging services.

Any accident, illness, security incident, theft, or emergency should be reported promptly to management. Employees should maintain emergency contact information and familiarize themselves with local emergency services.

14. Information Security

Employees traveling with Company devices or information are responsible for protecting confidential, proprietary, and sensitive information. Employees should use strong passwords, approved VPN connections, encrypted devices, and secure storage practices.

Sensitive information should never be left unattended in airports, hotels, conference facilities, vehicles, or public spaces.

15. Conference Attendance Expectations

Employees attending conferences, trade shows, workshops, or training programs on behalf of the Company are expected to act professionally and represent the Company positively. Attendance at approved sessions and events is expected unless business priorities require otherwise.

Employees should share relevant learnings with colleagues following attendance when appropriate.

16. Corporate Credit Card Usage

Employees issued Company credit cards must use them solely for approved business expenses. Personal charges are prohibited unless specifically authorized and reimbursed immediately.

Cardholders are responsible for maintaining receipts, reviewing statements, and complying with Company accounting requirements.

17. Combining Business and Personal Travel

Employees may combine business and personal travel with advance approval. Business activities must remain the primary purpose of the trip. Any incremental costs associated with personal travel are the employee's responsibility.

The Company will reimburse only legitimate business-related expenses.

18. Family Member and Companion Travel

Expenses associated with spouses, family members, friends, or companions are not reimbursable unless expressly approved. This includes airfare, meals, lodging upgrades, entertainment, and transportation costs.

19. Expense Reporting Requirements

Expense reports must be accurate, complete, and submitted within thirty calendar days following completion of travel. Required documentation includes itemized receipts, hotel folios, airline confirmations, conference registrations, parking receipts, and other supporting records.

Missing documentation may result in delayed or denied reimbursement.

20. Non-Reimbursable Expenses

Examples of non-reimbursable expenses include personal entertainment, personal shopping, family travel costs, traffic citations, parking violations, spa services, personal vacation expenses, excessive meal costs, unapproved upgrades, and expenses unrelated to business purposes.

21. Audits, Compliance, and Enforcement

The Company reserves the right to audit travel expenses and supporting documentation at any time. Employees must cooperate with audits and provide requested records.

Knowingly submitting false, misleading, or fraudulent expense reports may result in disciplinary action up to and including termination of employment.

22. Manager Responsibilities

Managers are responsible for reviewing travel requests, verifying business necessity, monitoring travel budgets, ensuring compliance with policy requirements, approving appropriate expenses, and supporting employees during travel-related situations.

23. Human Resources and Finance Responsibilities

Human Resources and Finance are responsible for maintaining this policy, providing guidance, reviewing reimbursement practices, supporting audits, ensuring consistency, and addressing employee questions regarding travel and expenses.

24. Frequently Asked Questions

Employees should contact their manager, Human Resources, or Finance whenever uncertainty exists regarding allowable expenses, travel approvals, reimbursement requirements, or policy interpretation. Employees are encouraged to seek clarification before incurring expenses.

25. Policy Administration

The Company reserves the right to interpret, revise, suspend, or terminate this policy at any time, subject to applicable laws. Nothing in this policy creates a contract of employment or alters the at-will employment relationship.

Employees are responsible for understanding and complying with the most current version of this policy.

Appendix 1: Travel Guidance

Employees should use sound judgment, maintain professionalism, protect Company assets, retain receipts, comply with local laws, communicate travel disruptions promptly, and represent the Company in a positive manner at all times. These guidelines are intended to support consistency, accountability, and employee safety throughout all phases of business travel. Employees should use sound judgment, maintain professionalism, protect Company assets, retain receipts, comply with local laws, communicate travel disruptions promptly, and represent the Company in a positive manner at all times. These guidelines are intended to support consistency, accountability, and employee safety throughout all phases of business travel. Employees should use sound judgment, maintain professionalism, protect Company assets, retain receipts, comply with local laws, communicate travel disruptions promptly, and represent the Company in a positive manner at all times. These guidelines are intended to support consistency, accountability, and employee safety throughout all phases of business travel.

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